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*Past Ghosts and Present Hauntings: How Caribbean Nations are Haunted by the Past*

““Unfilial son!”” cried the mother of Chen Pan, the main character in *Monkey Hunting* by Cristina García (39). In the form of an owl found in the forests of Cuba, Chen Pan’s mother haunts his desperate escape from indentureship to freedom, constantly reminding him of her disappointments in him as a son—the very same disappointments he feels in himself. Ghosts and other legacies of the past, including deceased family members like Chen Pan’s mother and past traumatic events relating to slavery and colonialism, frequent our main characters in both *Monkey Hunting* and *At the Full and Change of the Moon* by Dionne Brand. *At the Full and Change* features the story of Marie Ursule and how the trauma of the mass suicide she commits, that takes her life and all other slaves, except her infant daughter Bola, haunts the lives and journeys of her descendants. The spirits apparent in both novels, compounded by the nonlinear nature in which they are presented, suggest that elements of the past continue to influence and inform the present through cycles and patterns—both in a single lifetime and over the course of generations. Authors García and Brand both point back towards slavery and colonialism as the reason for these hauntings, for the regret, trauma, and disappointment that plague the characters from both novels have originated from these systems of power. Furthermore, because these characters are representative of their nations’ histories, they themselves are metaphors as to how those systems continue to influence and haunt Cuba and Trinidad, long after their dissolutions.

Chen Pan is haunted by the idea that he is not enough ever since he decided to leave China and realized that migrating to Cuba would not easily allow him to “*return a wealthy man, perhaps a stronger man*” like he was initially promised (5). Instead Chen Pan was treated as little more than a slave and forced to perform difficult labor at a brutal plantation, rendering unable to produce the fortune he promised his family before leaving. Through Chen Pan, we see how trauma from abuse under colonialism can give birth to doubt and disappointment, as Chen Pan is no longer satisfied with his choice to leave China and certainly unhappy with his new life. To promise to send his family fortune, and then be rendered unable to do so because of his new position as an indentured servant, also causes Chen Pan to fear he will be seen as a neglectful son and husband. García personifies these negative emotions through Chen Pan’s mother’s ghost whose screeches ““Unfilial son!”” echoes his own internal doubts (39). Her ghost keeps Chen Pan in a purgatory-like state for “nine months,” and it is in his escape that we see García’s first allusion to how trauma can contain characters in a fixed state for archaic periods of time (39). Chen Pan is trying to leave the plantation, but his hauntings do not allow him to achieve freedom as easily as he “stood up and walked away” (38). Instead, his trauma hinders most of his journey even as he is not physically at the plantation; it has a hold on him and haunts even after the initial event.

Chen Pan’s journey is reflective of Cuba’s history, and both individual and nation are haunted by the traumas gained as a result of the colonialism in their pasts. By further presenting Chen Pan’s trauma as cyclic, García presents the argument that Cuba’s past also continues to haunt and inform the present. Similarly to how Chen Pan’s trauma haunted and repeated itself throughout Chen Pan’s escape, Cuba’s past continues to hold the present in a similar state, where trauma continues to haunt and dominate the present. This takes shape in multiple forms,

including the social hierarchies and racism derived from the plantation structure, but also in the persistence of doubt and disappointment by those most affected. Again examining Chen Pan, we see that his past disillusionment never truly leaves him. At the end of the novel, he reflects on life and its “meaningless,” with his own existence at the forefront of his questions (237). He wonders if his life has amounted to anything and if anyone would “remember *him* in fifty years,” including his own family members (236). Chen Pan does not feel he has accomplished enough in his lifetime to earn a legacy great enough to be remembered—this mindset is a chronic consequence of Chen Pan’s indentured servitude when he believed himself to be a failure. It was developed by the trauma he suffered during that period of time and remains with him, repeating throughout his life. That is, even later in his life, after he has created a family and life for himself, Chen Pan is haunted that he *still* did not reach his fullest potential. Chen Pan’s trauma is repeated in cycles, and again framing our understanding of Cuba’s history through his journey, Cuba’s trauma from colonialism also continues to influence its present in these perpetual cycles.

Chen Pan’s journey is presented over the course of *Monkey Hunting* and interspersed with the stories of his descendants, including his great-grandson Domingo Chen, who is haunted by the idea that he is not achieving the potential that his family members expect out of him. He acknowledges this himself: “Domingo knew it drove his father crazy that he spent all his money [...] But what was he supposed to do?” (46). Domingo is conscious that his behavior is displeasing, and the narrative frames his questions as an internal defense to the shame he feels for disappointing his father—especially since his father, Pipo Chen, was the one who “taught him that the worst sin for a Chinese son was to neglect his dead ancestors” (106). Domingo is made to feel the same pressure to perform that Pipo himself feels. Pipo’s disposition is no doubt influenced by Chinese culture, but also developed from the idea that, if Chen Pan was able to

escape indentured servitude and earn fame and fortune, then so should his descendants be able to take on burdens and emerge from them stronger. Chen Pan's trauma is taken on by Pipo, who necessarily feels he must attain similar success as to not "let down" Chen Pan, whose struggles to provide his descendants a good life are handed from one generation to another.

When Pipo does not feel he is reaching his fullest potential and unable to live up to Chen Pan's legacy, he commits suicide. The unintentional transfer of trauma from one generation to the next is an example of how trauma lives on in cycles: Chen Pan's trauma lives on his descendants. Furthermore, García uses this generational framework to show how trauma creates more trauma—yet another way trauma sustains itself. After Pipo's suicide, Domingo's life is forever altered and "filtered through that look" on his father's face before he jumped (106). Domingo is constantly replaying the image of his father's disappointments in his own life and his son's. Domingo pictures his father's disappointments in his own life and his son's, and is so haunted by his father's memory, which plays into the pre-existing disappointments he already had in himself. Pipo's trauma, and therefore Chen Pan's trauma, has been passed down to Domingo. García uses this family as a very real portrayal of how trauma originating from colonialism can live on and invade a family structure. Why Cuba remains haunted is because such trauma is able to endure in this way, being handed down and built up from generation to the next, all the way into the present, where it continues to live and inform and influence.

It is important that we recognize García's narrative choice of telling this family saga in a nonlinear fashion, primarily by blending together multiple points of view and timelines. For example, weaving Chen Pan and Domingo's chronicles serves to underscore their similarities, especially those relating to repetitions of trauma in both generations. Both Chen Pan and Domingo's lives are suffocated with cycles of trauma, and that coupled with the time-bending

nature of the novel deconstructs the notion that “linear progress and historical destiny” are aligned (Moiles 175). Neither of these characters have lives that simply rise and rise, or rise and fall, but instead are constructed from patterns and cycles. The same is true of Cuba’s history, and the “novel’s structure works in circular fashion, not chronologically” to get this point across to the reader (175). Chen Pan struggles with patterns of trauma, and so does Domingo, and on a greater scale, so has Cuba over the course of its history—again noting that all three parties have trauma that primarily roots from colonialism. Furthermore, *Monkey Hunting*’s narrative parallels how trauma is cyclic in nature, once again departing from the idea of a “linear, progressive history” (175). That is, trauma is not something left in the past and moved on from, but continues to cycle through Cuba—not necessarily halting all progression, but instead creating stasis-like periods of time, adjacent to Chen Pan’s escape in the wilderness, that haunt the nation.

*At the Full and Change of the Moon* is similar to *Monkey Hunting* because it is also “recursive, refusing linear progression” (Evans 4). Brand also plays with point of view and the intermingling of timelines—in particular, her alignment of Bola, the woman who essentially started the entire family, and her descendant also named Bola, at the last few chapters of the novel. Why Brand uses this circular format is to explore the idea that Trinidad’s “history of plantation holds it back, circumscribing the present in the past” (14). Brand so promotes a similar idea that Trinidad’s traumatic legacy of colonialism continues to determine the present, and in particular, keeps the nation in a sort of stasis—not necessarily going forward nor backward, but remaining the same, trapped in cycles that repeat over again. A particular example of this is the above-mentioned second Bola, who is haunted by her mother. Bola and her sisters’ grief was immense: “We screamed and screamed and screamed and wept” (Brand 260–261). But while Bola’s sisters were able to recover and heal, Bola was never truly able to move on from her

mother's death, and remains in a perpetual state of denial. For example, after the funeral, Bola continuously visits her mother's grave, and this pattern of visitation lasts "for many days, and then many years" (266). Each and every day Bola stays with her mother, and she is essentially imprisoned in this cycle by her trauma. As Brand describes how they "whiled away time," she shows the extent to which Bola's trauma is able to ensnare her in a state where time is not necessarily moving, as she remains in this circular, repetitive cycle (267).

Though the starting point of Bola's trauma is mostly her mother's death, trauma that has been collected and built up through her family's generations also has a hand in it. Bola's birth mother is Eula, and earlier in the novel we see that she is tormented by trauma of her own, created by her siblings and larger family history. She is further haunted by her decisions, including when she "got rid" of Bola (250). Brand uses callous, indifferent language to describe Eula's reaction to her pregnancy, portraying Eula's doubt as having been caused by her past traumas. This language suggests that the reason why Eula sends Bola to her mother is not only because she "wanted to throw the child out of me," but also because Eula did not feel she was able to be the mother she wanted Bola to have (250). Furthermore, she goes no-contact with the family because she doesn't want to "saddle" Bola with "a memory that's not hers" (250). Eula knows from her own trauma how difficult longing for someone is, and does not want to pass that onto Bola. But at the same time, although Eula stays out of Bola's life for that reason, she also indirectly contributes to Bola's trauma later in life. That is, when Bola's sisters attempt to contact Eula, informing her that Bola has gone "'crazy,'" she does not respond (270). Eula does not interfere. And while we might argue if her coming down to Trinidad would have improved the situation or not, the fact remains that Eula's own trauma made it impossible for her to help Bola and in turn added to Bola's own.

Eula's trauma indirectly contributed to Bola's, and through this transfer of trauma Brand shows us how trauma can operate and perpetuate cycles. It is able to be passed down indirectly through generations, which is how it remains constant and *exists* even when the event that caused that trauma is of the past. Bola's mother is dead, but the trauma experienced from her death is alive and fresh and remains with Bola, even as she herself says that she "turned to a ghost" (278). Bola's transformation into a ghost—the one now doing the *haunting*—is Brand showing us the cyclic nature of it all: trauma creates ghosts, ghosts create trauma, and it just keeps going. Bola's individual trauma has expanded beyond her because trauma has no bounds—it cannot be contained within a single individual, which is why we have so many examples of it permeating through the generations of a family. To extend our scope, we look at Trinidad and consider that, a reason why Brand believes the nation is still trapped by its trauma from colonialism, is because of these ghosts, and that trauma cannot stay in the past when people in the present are continuously influenced by it. For example, Eula and Bola's trauma is also derivative of colonialism as they are both descendants of Marie Ursule, Bola's mother, whose mass suicide results in trauma that haunts the next generations of her family. The trauma from that event, although decades in the past, continues to inform and haunt—but in particular, we must examine the first Bola, who was the first affected by it.

The first Bola remembers the "vermillion morning," the very morning that Marie Ursule committed the mass suicide, and all the immediate events afterward, like how she got to Culebra Bay on the back of Kamena—who later left her and filled her with a "hunger for people" after his disappearance (66–69). Bola carries on the trauma of this event and its consequences, but curiously, she is not necessarily held by this trauma in the way that the second Bola, or even Eula, is. It plays out in her desires, including the various men she takes on as lovers and has

children with, and we could argue that itself is a cycle that still has a sense of forward momentum, personified in the life Bola gives and creates. And while Bola is haunted by the memory of her mother as she sings ““Marie Ursule”” and feels “something welling in her eyes,” she is not constantly “suffering” under her trauma, as she “didn’t have the patience for it” (69). For Bola, trauma is something that certainly impacts her, but not to the extent that it prevents her from living and creating life, which is a high contrast to the second Bola, whose trauma keeps her surrounded by death. Bola is not stuck in a stasis, a state of unmoving. Instead, she is living “in the best of places, where everything happened at the same time,” whereas the second Bola is only dwelling in the past (83). Brand purposefully breaks chronological order and contrasts these two characters at the end of her novel to make the argument that past trauma can live in the present, without necessarily holding it in an unmoving stasis. Again framing our understanding of these characters as to represent Trinidad’s history, Brand further argues that, though colonialism is a source of trauma and forever part of Trinidad’s history, and will continue to influence the present, Trinidad need not be *stuck* in those cycles of trauma. It can still have forward momentum despite it, and by further having Bola live in past, present, and future, Brand shows that trauma can exist in each iteration of a nation’s history without dominating it.

*Monkey Hunting* and *At the Full and Change of the Moon* feature multigenerational family sagas that are representative of their respective nations’ histories. Similar themes are present in both novels, including how past ghosts haunt the main families by transferring and creating the trauma originating from slavery and colonialism. What this suggests is that, on a larger scale, these same themes and events continue to haunt Cuba and Trinidad. Trauma created by these systems of power continue to repeat throughout history, exemplified through the cyclic nature of trauma and how it can replay in people’s lives and over the course of family



generations, as trauma is collected and passed down from one to another. Both novels present the idea that trauma is circular, and so generates the cycles that both Cuba and Trinidad find themselves subjected to. However, neither author necessarily promotes this trauma as the end-all, be-all: trauma, although ever-present and continuously influential, need not result in a forever stasis in Cuba nor Trinidad. *At the Full and Change* argues that trauma is something that the nation can exist with, without being dominated by it, and *Monkey Hunting*'s hope at the end of Chen Pan's life suggests the same. The legacies of colonialism need not dictate their nations' futures, and although trauma may never disappear completely, these nations like Chen Pan are "immortal" and can exist in a state where present and future are influenced, but not dominated, by traumas from the past (García 251).

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